

Strider's Report - Fire Tornado (Hotheads)

Party: Ruby (me), Leona, Kurze, Wynnstan

Objective: Investigate the fire tornado northwest of the Tall Spire.

Heading Out

We teleported from Haven to the Tall Spire to begin our expedition. There I met a woman named Leona wearing a bright blue plate armor. Very cool. Kurze and Wynnstan were already waiting for us.

From the Tall Spire, we headed northwest for around two to three hours until we reached the fire tornado.

It doesn't move.

At all.

It's just... there.

Inside the tornado are floating rocks connected by chains made entirely of fire. The rocks are stationary and placed throughout the tornado like little islands. In the very center hangs a massive glowing sphere.

It immediately reminded me of the floating mountain where we found baby Lapi.

I may have forgot to say that out loud and only quietly mentioned it to Wynnstan, it's a mistake I will not make again.

Getting Inside

For any future Striders reading this:

There are multiple ways to safely enter the tornado.

Our favorite method involved climbing into barrels soaked with water and rolling through the flames. Surprisingly effective.

Leona and I also confirmed that teleportation works perfectly fine through the flames, so anyone capable of short-range teleportation has a much easier time getting around.

One very important warning:

DO NOT TOUCH THE FIRE CHAINS.

They are not just hot.

They are made of actual fire and hurt about twice as much as you would expect.

The Floating Paths

There appear to be four moving stone platforms that travel along different routes.

From what we observed:

Path 1

- Travels all the way around the tornado while slowly climbing upward.

Path 2

- Travels toward the nearest floating structure.

Path 3

- Goes almost directly toward the giant sphere before continuing even higher.

Path 4

- ...I think it also reaches the upper parts of the tornado, but my quickly scribbled field notes became completely unreadable here. Sorry.

Strange Creatures

We chose Path 3.

The first creature we encountered was a strange mimic disguised as a treasure hoard. It didn't last very long.

Further along, we found something much stranger.

A giant salamander...

Axolotl...

Lizard thing.

It climbed along the fire chains toward us and honestly didn't seem very hostile. It mostly wanted cuddles.

Naturally, I told it we could absolutely cuddle...

...just on the next island.

My actual plan was to get it onto solid ground first, not on the chains where it almost made our platform riding the chains fall off.

Unfortunately, it decided standing directly in our way was a better idea.

So I convinced it that we'd cuddle later, inside the giant glowing sphere after we finished looking around.

It happily wandered toward the sphere.

In hindsight...

That might not have been my smartest idea.

The Dragon

Something inside the sphere woke up.

The sphere cracked open.

And out crawled...

A SUN DRAGON.

It looked different from most dragons I've heard about. More beast than person. It didn't look interested in talking.

It immediately went after Shamir.

We jumped from the floating island before it could reach us. Thankfully Wynnstan managed to slow our fall enough that we landed safely.

I quickly ushered Wynnstan and Kurze into my Bag of Holding while Leona and I teleported through the tornado to our horses.

We rode as fast as we could.

Unfortunately...

The dragon was faster.

Much faster.

If Leona hadn't used an incredibly rare magical item to summon a Roc, I don't think we would've made it back to the Tall Spire.

We definitely owe her one.

Door Challenge

Since we made it back alive and didn't want to return completely empty-handed, we decided to challenge one of the Tall Spire's doors.

This one threw us onto a pirate ship.

Our mission was to sink a nautiloid belonging to mind flayers. We also had our own crew on the ship, though it quickly became obvious they would eventually turn against us.

The fight ended up being much easier than expected.

Leona was incredible.

At one point she literally stopped the entire nautiloid with nothing but her glaive while standing on the water.

She and I teleported aboard the enemy ship and made quick work of the mind flayers while the others kept everything under control.

The ship's cannons were fascinating. We didn't have enough time to inspect them properly, but I definitely want to study something like them in the future.

Final Thoughts

- Water barrels work surprisingly well against magical fire.
- Teleportation makes traversing the tornado much easier.
- Do **NOT** touch the fire chains.
- If a giant cuddly salamander wants hugs near a mysterious glowing sphere... maybe don't encourage it.
- Sun dragons are very, very fast.
- Leona is amazing and probably saved all our lives.
- Also...

I still think baby Lapi is cuter, I wonder how they're doing.